



JOY IN THE CITY OF DREAMS

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People come to Mumbai to realise dreams, however audacious. Cricketers are no different. In 2011, M.S. Dhoni's men won the ODI World Cup before a roaring Wankhede Stadium, ending a 28-year wait for glory. For the women's team, the penance has been nearly twice as long. After faltering at the final hurdle thrice (2005, 2017, 2020) in ICC championships since the turn of the millennium, the Women in Blue needed a triumph to silence naysayers and their own dark doubts about their place in the sport. The opportunity presented itself on home soil.

Between October 19 and November 2, the belief of fair-weather fans, drawn to invest in the side by the hullabaloo of tournament cricket, wavered erratically. From immovable faith to misogynistic jokes, the Indian team's popularity swung through the volatile tunnels of social media and popular discourse.

But Navi Mumbai, a cherished city for the team by virtue of its increased bilateral fixtures and the Women's Premier League (WPL), doesn't believe in being flippant.

Roma, a jersey seller from Kolkata who hops on a train with her wares to every major cricketing fixture in the country, saw the economic upside of that faith.

"We typically print 500-1000 jerseys for every few games. I exhausted my stock before the semifinal," she told Sportstar hours before the final. She was among the few to bring an extra bag of 'Smriti' and 'Harman' jerseys.

After a point, she had to tell eager fans, "Those are over, can I give you Virat's number 18 instead?"

Hundreds, if not thousands, of fans lined up outside the D.Y. Patil Stadium, hoping to find tickets to the game, while cops simply tapped the massive sold-out sign whenever someone requested entry. Passes for the final, priced at Rs. 150 initially, had skyrocketed to 30 times that number when India pushed Australia off the knockout cliff, and rose to as high as Rs. 25,000 for the cheapest seats.

Among those desperate for seats were Smita and her daughter Samiksha, who was incidentally celebrating her birthday. Smita played gully cricket in an era when the sport was culturally not so accommodating of women.

"Meri bachhi khelegi ab, Jemi jaise banegi (She will play and become like Jemimah Rodrigues)," she exclaimed about her academy-going child. The family had printed a flex of the Mumbai-born batting maverick, chanting for every player as they